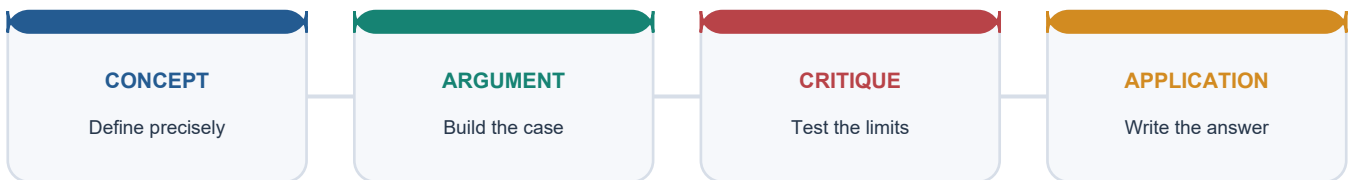


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Central Asian Contacts: Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Kushanas - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Central Asian Contacts: Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Kushanas - Solved Practice Workbook	3
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	3
32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS	3
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	14
PYQ 01 - 2019 GS-I Mains Q1: Gandhara art	14
Adjacent PYQ 02 - 2020 Prelims GS-I Q22: Buddhist schools	15
Adjacent PYQ 03 - 2023 Prelims GS-I Q46: Milinda-panha attribution	15
SIX ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS - EXACT COUNT	15
ORIGINAL MAINS 10-MARKER 1 - Distinct frontier polities	15
ORIGINAL MAINS 10-MARKER 2 - Menander and the Milindapanha	16
ORIGINAL MAINS 15-MARKER 1 - Shaka satrapal rule	16
ORIGINAL MAINS 15-MARKER 2 - Kushana formation and imperial geography	17
ORIGINAL MAINS 20-MARKER 1 - Mutual impact	17
ORIGINAL MAINS 20-MARKER 2 - Sources, chronology and limits	18

Central Asian Contacts: Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Kushanas - Solved Practice Workbook

Practice contract: exactly 32 original hard MCQs precede the verified PYQ block; strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation repeats eight times; 128 option explanations and 32 examiner traps are separately identifiable. Official PYQ wording and key status are preserved.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS

These are original questions, not UPSC PYQs. Correct keys rotate A -> B -> C -> D exactly eight times. All 128 option explanations and all 32 examiner traps are separately identifiable.

Q1

Which frame best describes post-Mauryan Central Asian contacts?

- A. Distinct Indo-Greek, Shaka, Indo-Parthian and Kushana formations overlapped across regions and routes.
- B. A single foreign dynasty replaced the Mauryas everywhere at one date.
- C. All four groups were branches of the Yuezhi confederation.
- D. Political change was confined to one invasion of the Punjab.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. The sequence is regional and overlapping; separate origins, dynasties and archives must be retained. [Q01-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. No uniform all-India replacement chronology is supported by coins, inscriptions or archaeology. [Q01-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Only the Kushanas arose from the Guishuang branch of the Great Yuezhi. [Q01-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Migration, settlement, alliance, commerce and patronage continued beyond military entry. [Q01-D]

Examiner trap 1: Do not collapse all foreign-origin rulers into one dynasty or one invasion wave.

Q2

For reconstructing fragmented Indo-Greek dynasties, which evidence is most diagnostic?

- A. Later Puranic lists without corroboration.
- B. Named portrait coins with legends, monograms, weights and overstrike sequences.
- C. The distribution of one pottery type treated as a political map.
- D. A single Buddhist dialogue read as a court chronicle.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. Later lists can preserve memory but do not supply a complete contemporary ruler sequence. [Q02-A]
- **B:** Correct. Numismatic typology can identify rulers and relative sequences, though not exact borders. [Q02-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Material culture can circulate beyond dynastic or linguistic frontiers. [Q02-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. The Milindapanha is layered religious literature, not a continuous political annal. [Q02-D]

Examiner trap 2: A coin findspot indicates circulation; it does not by itself prove territorial rule.

Q3

Demetrius is most safely associated with which development?

- A. The repair of the Sudarshana lake recorded at Junagadh.
- B. The foundation of the Shaka era in 78 CE.
- C. An early second-century BCE Bactrian Greek movement south of the Hindu Kush.
- D. The final unification of the five Yuezhi principalities.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. The Junagadh repair belongs to Rudradaman's Western Kshatrapa record. [Q03-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. The founder of the Shaka era is debated and should not be assigned to Demetrius. [Q03-B]
- **C:** Correct. Coins support an early Indo-Greek expansion, while its precise route and extent remain debated. [Q03-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Kushana consolidation belongs to Kujula Kadphises, not an Indo-Greek ruler. [Q03-D]

Examiner trap 3: Demetrius is an Indo-Greek chronological anchor, not proof of a Bactria-to-Pataliputra empire.

Q4

Which statement about Menander is best supported?

- A. He was the author of the Milindapanha.
- B. He was a Kardamaka Mahakshatrapa.
- C. His entire biography is fixed by contemporary inscriptions.
- D. He was an Indo-Greek ruler securely known from coins and remembered as Milinda in Buddhist dialogue tradition.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. The text stages dialogue between Milinda and Nagasena; it is not a royal autobiography. [Q04-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Kardamaka rulers such as Chashtana and Rudradaman belong to Western Kshatrapa history. [Q04-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. The archive remains fragmentary and literary traditions are later and layered. [Q04-C]
- **D:** Correct. Numismatics anchors the ruler; the text illuminates intellectual memory with genre limits. [Q04-D]

Examiner trap 4: Menander's coins and the Milindapanha are complementary sources, not interchangeable proof.

Q5

The Milindapanha is most useful when treated as:

- A. A layered Buddhist dialogue illuminating reasoning and Menander's cultural memory.
- B. An official verbatim transcript of Menander's court.
- C. A contemporary Greek military dispatch.
- D. Conclusive proof that every Indo-Greek subject became Buddhist.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Its dialogic form preserves Buddhist argument and the remembered figure of Milinda. [Q05-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Redaction, transmission and literary construction prevent transcript-level use. [Q05-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Its genre and doctrinal purpose are Buddhist, not diplomatic or military reporting. [Q05-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. A royal association cannot establish population-wide conversion or exclusive belief. [Q05-D]

Examiner trap 5: Nagasena is the interlocutor; Nagarjuna is a different figure and not the work's author.

Q6

What does the Heliodorus pillar at Besnagar directly establish?

- A. Menander founded a monastery at Mathura.
- B. An envoy of Antialcidas identified as a Bhagavata and dedicated a Garuda pillar to Vasudeva.
- C. All Indo-Greeks collectively converted to Vaishnavism.
- D. The Kushanas governed Vidisha through a satrap.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. The inscription concerns Heliodorus, Antialcidas and Bhagabhadra, not Menander's monastery. [Q06-A]
- **B:** Correct. It is inscriptional evidence for diplomacy, mobility and individual religious affiliation. [Q06-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. One ambassador's self-identification cannot represent an entire political community. [Q06-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. The record predates Kushana rule and does not create a Kushana province. [Q06-D]

Examiner trap 6: Use Heliodorus for diplomacy and cultural agency, never for mass-conversion claims.

Q7

Which pairing best preserves early Shaka chronology in the north-west?

- A. Maues-Guishuang unification; Azes-Rabatak genealogy.
- B. Maues-Junagadh Sanskrit prashasti; Azes-Mathura devakula.
- C. Maues-Taxila/Gandhara coins and inscriptional evidence; Azes-later north-western coin sequence and debated era association.
- D. Maues-Satavahana matronymics; Azes-Ashokan dhamma.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. Guishuang and Rabatak belong to Kushana formation and Kanishka's genealogy. [Q07-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Junagadh belongs to Rudradaman; the devakula belongs to Kushana royal imagery. [Q07-B]
- **C:** Correct. Both rulers are reconstructed primarily through north-western numismatic and epigraphic evidence. [Q07-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. These are unrelated Deccan and Mauryan evidence classes. [Q07-D]

Examiner trap 7: The Azes-Vikrama-era equation is debated; never present it as settled chronology.

Q8

How should Shaka political history be organised?

- A. As one dynasty ruling Taxila, Mathura and western India simultaneously.
- B. As a purely nomadic phase with no settled institutions.
- C. As a short interval without regional continuities.
- D. As several regional branches whose dates and authority overlapped with Indo-Greek, Pahlava, Satavahana and Kushana powers.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. North-western, Mathura and western branches cannot be merged into one continuous house. [Q08-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Coins, inscriptions, donations and satrapal titles show durable regional institutions. [Q08-B]

- **C:** Incorrect. Western Kshatrapas persisted for centuries and interacted with Deccan and coastal networks. [Q08-C]
- **D:** Correct. Regionalisation explains both shared titles and divergent political histories. [Q08-D]

Examiner trap 8: A broad succession chart must not erase parallel rulers and region-specific chronologies.

Q9

The titles kshatrapa and mahakshatrapa are best understood as:

- A. Flexible satrapal titles whose actual powers varied and could support delegated rule or regional sovereignty.
- B. Fixed equivalents of modern district magistrate and governor.
- C. Exclusively Buddhist monastic ranks.
- D. Titles used only by Kushana kings at Purushapura.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Their Iranian background was adapted in different north-western, Mathura and western contexts. [Q09-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Modern administrative equations manufacture precision absent from the evidence. [Q09-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. The titles belong to political governance, not monastic organisation. [Q09-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Shaka rulers prominently used them, and practice was not confined to one city. [Q09-D]

Examiner trap 9: A title reveals claimed rank, not a complete constitutional job description.

Q10

Which evidence most securely links Nahapana's displacement to Gautamiputra Satakarni?

- A. A later legend of Kanishka's council.
- B. Gautamiputra's overstrikes on Nahapana's silver coins.
- C. The Heliodorus pillar.
- D. A Chinese account of Yuezhi migration.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. Buddhist council traditions do not address the western Deccan conflict. [Q10-A]
- **B:** Correct. Overstriking is direct numismatic evidence of political reversal and metal reuse. [Q10-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Besnagar records Indo-Greek diplomacy and Bhagavata affiliation. [Q10-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Chinese histories illuminate Central Asian movement, not this regional contest. [Q10-D]

Examiner trap 10: Overstrikes show displacement but do not map every campaign or date every locality.

Q11

Rudradaman I's Junagadh inscription is especially valuable because it:

- A. Is a neutral census of every Western Kshatrapa district.
- B. Proves Sanskrit instantly replaced Prakrit across India.
- C. Combines a dated Shaka-era record, Sudarshana-lake repair, genealogy, conquest claims and courtly Sanskrit.
- D. Shows Rudradaman was a Satavahana ruler.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. It is a royal prashasti whose selectivity and praise require criticism. [Q11-A]

- **B:** Incorrect. The inscription is a major Sanskrit landmark, but Prakrit and other languages continued. [Q11-B]
- **C:** Correct. Its multiple dimensions make it a prime epigraphic anchor for polity, public works and language. [Q11-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Rudradaman was a Kardamaka Western Kshatrpa who fought a Satakarni ruler. [Q11-D]

Examiner trap 11: Shaka year 72 dates the inscription; it does not identify the founder of the Shaka era.

Q12

Gondophares should be placed in which political formation?

- A. The Indo-Greek house of Menander.
- B. The Kardamaka Western Kshatrapas.
- C. The Kushana line after Vasudeva.
- D. The Indo-Parthian or Pahlava layer, known through coins and inscriptions such as Takht-i-Bahi.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. Shared north-western coin idioms do not make Gondophares Indo-Greek. [Q12-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Kardamaka rule is associated with Chashtana and Rudradaman in western India. [Q12-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Gondophares precedes high Kushana consolidation and belongs to a distinct dynasty. [Q12-C]
- **D:** Correct. Contemporary material anchors the ruler more firmly than later Christian narrative. [Q12-D]

Examiner trap 12: The Acts of Thomas association is later tradition and cannot verify every journey detail.

Q13

The Great Yuezhi movement is reconstructed chiefly by correlating:

- A. Chinese historical accounts with Central Asian archaeology, coins and later Kushana evidence.
- B. Only the Junagadh inscription.
- C. Only the Milindapanha.
- D. Sangam poems with Gupta land grants.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Textual ethnonyms and migration narratives require archaeological and numismatic correlation. [Q13-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Junagadh concerns Western Kshatrpa public works and royal praise. [Q13-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. The dialogue tradition concerns Menander and Buddhist reasoning. [Q13-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. These sources belong to different periods and cannot establish Yuezhi formation. [Q13-D]

Examiner trap 13: Yuezhi is the wider confederation; Kushana was the Guishuang branch that gained predominance.

Q14

Kujula Kadphises is best associated with:

- A. Founding the Shaka era beyond dispute.
- B. Early Kushana consolidation and expansion south of the Hindu Kush, visible mainly through coins.
- C. Composing the Buddhacharita.
- D. Issuing the Junagadh prashasti.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. The era-founder question is separate and disputed. [Q14-A]
- **B:** Correct. Kujula is the foundational dynastic consolidator, although dates and territorial stages remain approximate. [Q14-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Buddhacharita is associated with Ashvaghosha, whose court biography is itself debated. [Q14-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Junagadh belongs to Rudradaman, not the Kushana founder. [Q14-D]

Examiner trap 14: Do not project Kanishka's later imperial reach backward onto Kujula's entire reign.

Q15

Which description of Vima Kadphises is most defensible?

- A. He issued no gold and used only Buddhist imagery.
- B. He was the Indo-Parthian king linked to St Thomas.
- C. His gold and copper issues display expanding monetary capacity and Shiva/Oesho-related iconography.
- D. He is known only from the Milindapanha.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. His coinage includes major gold/copper issues and non-Buddhist imagery. [Q15-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. That later literary association concerns Gondophares. [Q15-B]
- **C:** Correct. The coins support monetary and ideological analysis, not a simple confession of faith. [Q15-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. The Milindapanha centres on Menander/Milinda. [Q15-D]

Examiner trap 15: Kushana gold cannot be explained solely by Roman trade; tribute, bullion and fiscal choices also mattered.

Q16

Which chronology statement is safest?

- A. Kanishka certainly founded the Shaka era in 78 CE.
- B. Every Kushana inscription uses the same undisputed era.
- C. Kanishka's accession can be dated to one exact year without debate.
- D. The Shaka era begins in 78 CE, while a major modern chronology places Kanishka around 127 CE and keeps the association contested.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. This is an older position, not a secure consensus. [Q16-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Era usage and conversion across inscriptions remain disputed. [Q16-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Synchronisms and inscriptional eras support ranges rather than universal certainty. [Q16-C]
- **D:** Correct. It preserves the fixed era date while qualifying Kanishka's accession debate. [Q16-D]

Examiner trap 16: Never equate 78 CE automatically with Kanishka's accession.

Q17

Why is the Rabatak inscription central to Kushana history?

- A. It gives a Bactrian-in-Greek-script royal text with genealogy, titulature, deity language and eastern city claims.
- B. It is a Greek-language biography of Menander.
- C. It is the official transcript of Kanishka's Buddhist council.
- D. It proves uniform Kushana taxation throughout the Ganga delta.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Rabatak is a major dynastic and ideological source, though readings and territorial claims require caution. [Q17-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Menander belongs to Indo-Greek numismatic and Buddhist literary evidence. [Q17-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Council narratives come from later Buddhist traditions, not Rabatak. [Q17-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. A royal city list or universal claim cannot establish equal administrative depth. [Q17-D]

Examiner trap 17: Rabatak clarifies ruler order and claims; it does not turn every named city into uniformly governed territory.

Q18

Kushana political geography is best represented as:

- A. A maritime kingdom with no Central Asian core.
- B. A multi-centred network linking Bactria, Kapisa/Begram, Purushapura, Taxila and Mathura through varied tiers of control.
- C. A uniform province system centred only at Pataliputra.
- D. An empire whose borders equal all Kushana coin findspots.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. Overland Bactrian and north-western centres were foundational. [Q18-A]
- **B:** Correct. Multiple centres and intermediaries better fit the uneven evidence than a single-capital model. [Q18-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Pataliputra appears in claims, but was not the sole secure administrative centre. [Q18-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Coins moved through exchange, imitation and later circulation. [Q18-D]

Examiner trap 18: Purushapura, Mathura and Bactria were major centres; avoid declaring one exclusive capital for every phase.

Q19

What does a Kushana coin found far east of the strongest imperial core prove first?

- A. Direct annexation and taxation of the findspot.
- B. The location of the issuing mint.
- C. Circulation, exchange or deposition that requires contextual interpretation.
- D. A permanent Kushana garrison.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. Political sovereignty needs corroborating inscriptional, archaeological or administrative evidence. [Q19-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Findspot and mint location are different numismatic variables. [Q19-B]
- **C:** Correct. Context, hoard composition, wear and imitation determine the strength of further inference. [Q19-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. A military presence cannot be inferred from a portable object alone. [Q19-D]

Examiner trap 19: Rule, influence and coin circulation are three different map layers.

Q20

The Kushana titles shaonano shao and devaputra most directly express:

- A. Guild membership and monastic rank.

- B. Abolition of regional intermediaries.
- C. A modern doctrine of popular sovereignty.
- D. King-of-kings and son-of-god claims that exalted royal authority across cultural idioms.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. These are royal titles, not corporate or religious offices. [Q20-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Exalted sovereignty could coexist with satraps and local intermediaries. [Q20-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. The titles sacralise monarchy rather than electoral legitimacy. [Q20-C]
- **D:** Correct. Iranian, Central Asian and Indic translations contributed to an imperial vocabulary. [Q20-D]

Examiner trap 20: Divine royal titles show ideology; they do not by themselves prove literal universal king-worship.

Q21

Which description of the Silk Routes is most accurate for this topic?

- A. Changing overland corridors connected China, the Tarim Basin, Bactria, Gandhara and India, while maritime routes linked western ports to West Asia and Rome.
- B. One paved road was owned continuously by Kanishka.
- C. Only Chinese silk travelled and no Indian goods moved.
- D. Sea trade made caravan cities irrelevant.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Plural routes, nodes and institutions explain movement better than one imperial highway. [Q21-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. States taxed and protected segments but did not own one stable transcontinental road. [Q21-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Goods, people, ideas and bullion moved in several directions. [Q21-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Inland and maritime circuits were connected rather than mutually exclusive. [Q21-D]

Examiner trap 21: Write Silk Routes in the plural and identify nodes, actors and changing control.

Q22

What is the strongest inference from Kushana gold coinage?

- A. Every peasant household used gold daily.
- B. The state and elite circuits possessed substantial high-value monetary and bullion capacity.
- C. Rome politically controlled the Kushana Empire.
- D. Copper and barter disappeared from the economy.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. Gold circulation was socially and regionally selective. [Q22-A]
- **B:** Correct. Large issues show fiscal and commercial capacity without proving universal prosperity. [Q22-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Roman contacts and bullion flows do not imply Roman sovereignty. [Q22-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Copper coinage and non-monetary exchange continued. [Q22-D]

Examiner trap 22: Monetisation was differentiated by denomination, region and social use.

Q23

Which statement about cavalry and the stirrup is historically safest?

- A. Central Asian rulers invented every Indian military technique.

- B. Kushanas certainly introduced the modern iron stirrup across India in the first century CE.
- C. Mounted warfare, saddles, horse gear and trousered cavalry gained visibility, but the secure dating and diffusion of true stirrups require separate archaeological proof.
- D. Coins showing horsemen prove identical battlefield practice in every province.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. Military change emerged through adaptation, exchange and local continuities. [Q23-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Stirrup chronology is contested; broad early claims often confuse toe loops or riding equipment with true stirrups. [Q23-B]
- **C:** Correct. It credits cavalry influence while preserving technological and evidentiary caution. [Q23-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Royal iconography is not a complete military manual or deployment record. [Q23-D]

Examiner trap 23: Credit stronger cavalry and horse gear cautiously; do not make the stirrup a certain Kushana invention.

Q24

Kushana coin pantheons are best interpreted as:

- A. Proof that the population practised one uniform syncretic religion.
- B. Random decoration without political communication.
- C. Evidence that Kanishka was exclusively Buddhist.
- D. Plural royal iconography addressing varied constituencies through Iranian, Greek, Indian and Buddhist divine forms.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. Coin imagery cannot measure uniform popular belief. [Q24-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Named deities and changing legends were deliberate instruments of royal representation. [Q24-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Buddhist patronage coexisted with Nana, Miiro, Mao, Oesho and other figures. [Q24-C]
- **D:** Correct. The iconographic repertoire reveals cosmopolitan legitimation, not one private creed. [Q24-D]

Examiner trap 24: A deity on a coin proves representation and policy more securely than personal conversion.

Q25

Which statement best distinguishes Kanishka's patronage from Mahayana origins?

- A. Kanishka was a major Buddhist patron, but Mahayana developed through longer textual, monastic and social processes.
- B. Kanishka wrote every Mahayana sutra.
- C. The fourth council is documented by a contemporary official transcript.
- D. Buddhist transmission to Central Asia depended only on royal missions.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Royal patronage mattered without single-handedly creating a diverse movement. [Q25-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Mahayana literature emerged across communities and periods. [Q25-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Council location, composition and results survive chiefly in later traditions. [Q25-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Monks, translators, merchants, monasteries and routes were indispensable. [Q25-D]

Examiner trap 25: Treat the Kashmir council and Mahayana claims as traditions with source labels, not uncontested events.

Q26

Gandhara art is most accurately described as:

- A. Pure Greek sculpture transplanted unchanged into India.
- B. A Buddhist artistic tradition of north-western workshops combining Hellenistic, Iranian, Central Asian and Indic resources.
- C. A copy of Mathura with no regional material base.
- D. A Gupta invention unrelated to Kushana patronage.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. Subject, ritual setting, patrons and workshop history were locally embedded. [Q26-A]
- **B:** Correct. Schist/stucco, modelled bodies, drapery and frontier patronage formed a layered regional idiom. [Q26-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Gandhara and Mathura interacted but maintained different materials and conventions. [Q26-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Its major phases precede and overlap Kushana-era networks. [Q26-D]

Examiner trap 26: Style is not ethnicity: Hellenised form does not prove that every sculptor was Greek.

Q27

Which contrast between Mathura and Gandhara is strongest?

- A. Mathura produced no Buddhist images.
- B. Gandhara alone created anthropomorphic Buddha images beyond dispute.
- C. Mathura used red sandstone and older local idioms across Buddhist, Jaina, Brahmanical and royal images, while Gandhara favoured north-western schist/stucco traditions.
- D. Mathura merely copied Roman marble sculpture.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. Mathura was a major centre of Buddhist image production. [Q27-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Priority and causation remain debated; both centres contributed. [Q27-B]
- **C:** Correct. Material, religious range and workshop idiom provide a defensible comparison. [Q27-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Mathura had deep local sculptural continuities and did not depend on marble. [Q27-D]

Examiner trap 27: Do not reduce Gandhara to foreign and Mathura to isolated indigenous purity.

Q28

Which language-script pairing is correct?

- A. Rabatak-Sanskrit in Kharoshthi.
- B. Indo-Greek coins-Latin in Brahmi.
- C. Junagadh-Bactrian in Greek script.
- D. Rabatak-Bactrian in Greek script; many Indo-Greek issues-Greek and Prakrit legends using Greek and Kharoshthi.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. Rabatak's major royal text is Bactrian written in Greek script. [Q28-A]

- **B:** Incorrect. Indo-Greek bilingualism did not use Latin as its standard partner. [Q28-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Rudradaman's Junagadh inscription is a major Sanskrit Brahmi record. [Q28-C]
- **D:** Correct. It separates language from script and shows regionally adapted political communication. [Q28-D]

Examiner trap 28: Greek script does not always mean Greek language; Bactrian is the key Kushana example.

Q29

How should claims about calendars, clothing and science be framed?

- **A:** As selective, evidence-specific exchanges: the Shaka era is distinct from Kanishka's disputed accession; tunics/trousers appear in contact-zone imagery; astronomical vocabulary moved without proving wholesale importation.
- **B:** Every calendar, garment and scientific idea in India arrived with one invasion.
- **C:** The national Shaka calendar proves Kanishka founded the era.
- **D:** Royal dress on one statue establishes the clothing of every social class.

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct. Each claim is bounded by its own textual, iconographic or chronological evidence. [Q29-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. This monocausal diffusion model erases earlier traditions and local adaptation. [Q29-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Modern calendar usage and the 78 CE era do not resolve Kanishka's chronology. [Q29-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Elite representation cannot be generalised to population-wide dress. [Q29-D]

Examiner trap 29: Separate transmission from invention, and modern calendar use from ancient era-founder debates.

Q30

Which formulation best captures social assimilation?

- **A:** Foreign-origin elites instantly lost all previous cultural forms.
- **B:** Integration was negotiated through titles, language, marriage, donation, guilds and cults, while identities and power remained unequal and regionally varied.
- **C:** Brahmanical labels provide a complete census of lived status.
- **D:** Only kings participated in cultural exchange.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. Iranian, Hellenistic and Central Asian idioms remained visible within new syntheses. [Q30-A]
- **B:** Correct. The process was reciprocal and institutional rather than one-way absorption. [Q30-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Normative classifications express social argument, not uniform empirical reality. [Q30-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Merchants, monks, artisans, officers and families were active agents. [Q30-D]

Examiner trap 30: Prefer cosmopolitan synthesis or negotiated adaptation to a simple one-way Indianisation story.

Q31

Which account of Kushana decline is most defensible?

- **A:** One invasion ended all Kushana authority, trade and Buddhism at once.
- **B:** Gold coinage stopped everywhere on a single date.
- **C:** Dynastic division, Sasanian pressure, regional successors and changing fiscal-route conditions produced staggered contraction with cultural continuities.
- **D:** The Western Kshatrapas vanished before Kushana formation.

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. Political fragmentation and cultural transmission followed different timelines. [Q31-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Coin sequences vary by region and do not alone establish total economic collapse. [Q31-B]
- **C:** Correct. A multi-causal, regional account fits the evidence and the persistence of successor formations. [Q31-C]
- **D:** Incorrect. Western Kshatrapa power overlapped and continued for centuries. [Q31-D]

Examiner trap 31: Use ended-persisted-transformed, not a single-cause dark-age narrative.

Q32

Which method gives the most reliable overall reconstruction?

- A. Treat every later legend as literal history.
- B. Draw borders from the widest coin distribution.
- C. Assume art style reveals the ethnicity of each sculptor.
- D. Triangulate coins, inscriptions, archaeology, Chinese/classical texts and Buddhist traditions, grading each claim by date, genre, region and scale.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect. Later traditions are valuable for memory and doctrine but require corroboration. [Q32-A]
- **B:** Incorrect. Portable money can travel, be imitated or remain in use after political change. [Q32-B]
- **C:** Incorrect. Workshops and styles are cultural practices, not biological labels. [Q32-C]
- **D:** Correct. Converging independent evidence permits bounded conclusions without false precision. [Q32-D]

Examiner trap 32: The archive is fragmented, not useless; qualification increases rather than weakens an answer.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PYQ 01 - 2019 GS-I Mains Q1: Gandhara art

Verified question: "Highlight the Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in the Gandhara art." (10 marks; 150 words)

Status: Exact wording and metadata verified from the locally held official UPSC paper. Mains has no objective key.

Demand decoding: "Highlight" requires a compact identification of both named strands, concrete artistic evidence and a qualified judgement.

Model answer (145 words):

Gandhara was a Buddhist artistic tradition produced in north-western workshops where Greco-Bactrian forms interacted with Central Asian mobility and Kushana patronage. **Claim:** Greco-Bactrian elements shaped visual treatment. **Evidence:** schist and stucco figures display modelled anatomy, wavy hair, naturalistic faces and heavy folded drapery. **Analysis:** these conventions made Buddhist figures legible through a Hellenised visual repertoire. **Qualification:** style does not establish that every artisan was Greek.

Claim: Central Asian elements entered chiefly through political and social context. **Evidence:** Kushana patronage, tunics, trousers and boots in frontier imagery, royal portraiture, and routes linking Bactria with Gandhara. **Analysis:** mobile courts, donors and workshops sustained artistic exchange. **Qualification:** Central Asia was internally diverse.

The subjects-Buddha, bodhisattvas and Buddhist narratives-remained rooted in South Asian religious settings. Mathura's red-sandstone idiom confirms that Buddha imagery was multi-centred. Gandhara was therefore a layered Buddhist synthesis, not imported Greek art.

Executable answer spine: definition -> Greco-Bactrian form -> Central Asian patronage/costume/routes -> Buddhist subject -> Mathura control -> qualified verdict.

Adjacent PYQ 02 - 2020 Prelims GS-I Q22: Buddhist schools

Verified question form: Consider the statements: (1) Sthaviravadins belong to Mahayana Buddhism; (2) Lokottaravadin was an offshoot of the Mahasanghika sect; (3) the deification of Buddha by Mahasanghikas fostered Mahayana Buddhism. Which statements are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer/status: B - analytically inferred; not labelled an official key. The question wording is verified from the local official paper, but no local official key is held.

Statement analysis: Statement 1 is incorrect because Sthaviravada belongs to early Buddhist-school traditions, not Mahayana. Statement 2 is correct: Lokottaravada developed within the Mahasanghika stream. Statement 3 is accepted in the question's doctrinal-history framing. Topic 16 uses this only to prevent the claim that Kanishka founded Mahayana; primary ownership remains Topic 10.

Adjacent PYQ 03 - 2023 Prelims GS-I Q46: Milinda-panha attribution

Verified question form: The official question matches *Devichandraguptam*, *Hammira-Mahakavya*, *Milinda-panha* and *Nitivakyamrita* with named figures and asks how many pairs are correct.

Answer/status: Two pairs - analytically inferred; not labelled an official key. Exact wording is controlled by the locally held official paper; no local official key is held.

Pair analysis: *Devichandraguptam* is associated with Vishakhadatta, not Bilhana. *Hammira-Mahakavya* is associated with Nayachandra Suri. *Milinda-panha* centres on Milinda and Nagasena, not Nagarjuna. *Nitivakyamrita* is associated with Somadeva Suri. This is an adjacent source-literacy PYQ; primary ownership remains Topic 02.

SIX ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS - EXACT COUNT

ORIGINAL MAINS 10-MARKER 1 - Distinct frontier polities

Question: Distinguish the Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Pahlavas and Kushanas by origin, political form and evidence. (10 marks; maximum 150 words)

Demand decoding: Distinguish requires four compact contrasts, not a ruler catalogue.

Model answer (132 words):

The four formations overlapped but were not one dynasty. **Claim:** Indo-Greeks emerged from Bactrian Greek politics. **Evidence:** named portrait coins with Greek-Prakrit legends identify rulers such as Menander. **Analysis:** coinage reveals adapted authority. **Qualification:** circulation is not a frontier. **Claim:** Shakas formed several regional satrapal lines. **Evidence:** Maues, Rajuvula, Nahapana and Rudradaman appear in coins and inscriptions. **Analysis:** kshatrapa rule joined delegation with autonomy. **Qualification:** branches had separate chronologies. **Claim:** Pahlavas were Indo-Parthian rulers. **Evidence:** Gondophares is anchored by coins and Takht-i-Bahi. **Analysis:** they were a substantive frontier polity. **Qualification:** later St Thomas traditions are not contemporary proof. **Claim:** Kushanas arose from the Guishuang Yuezhi. **Evidence:** Chinese histories, Kujula's coins and Rabatak genealogy. **Analysis:** they built a transregional, multi-centred empire. **Qualification:** city claims and coin finds do not prove uniform control.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive, uses named evidence analytically and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Underline each causal verb and source-status qualifier; never add an unverified date, quotation or official key.

ORIGINAL MAINS 10-MARKER 2 - Menander and the Milindapanha

Question: Assess the historical value and limitations of the Milindapanha for understanding Menander. (10 marks; maximum 150 words)

Demand decoding: Assess requires utility and limitation, with numismatic corroboration.

Model answer (133 words):

The *Milindapanha* is valuable less as biography than as evidence of Buddhist intellectual memory around an Indo-Greek king. **Claim:** it presents Milinda questioning the monk Nagasena. **Evidence:** its dialogic problems-such as the chariot analogy-organise Buddhist reasoning. **Analysis:** the choice of a foreign-origin king reveals a remembered arena of debate and cultural participation. **Qualification:** the text is layered and cannot be treated as a verbatim court transcript. **Claim:** Menander was a historical ruler. **Evidence:** a large corpus of named portrait coins and wide circulation independently anchors his authority and links him with Sagala. **Analysis:** numismatics corrects literary overreach. **Qualification:** coins do not prove every event or exclusive conversion. Plutarch preserves another later memory, but not a contemporary Indian chronicle. Thus text plus coins illuminate reception and interaction more securely than exact biography.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive, uses named evidence analytically and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Underline each causal verb and source-status qualifier; never add an unverified date, quotation or official key.

ORIGINAL MAINS 15-MARKER 1 - Shaka satrapal rule

Question: Analyse Shaka satrapal rule with special reference to Maues, Nahapana and Rudradaman. (15 marks; maximum 250 words)

Demand decoding: Analyse requires the operating mechanism, regional examples and limits of the title-based reconstruction.

Model answer (172 words):

Shaka political history consisted of regional formations rather than one all-India dynasty. **Claim:** satrapal titles enabled delegated expansion. **Evidence:** rulers used *kshatrpa* and *mahakshatrpa* in the north-west, Mathura and western India. **Analysis:** the system lowered the cost of ruling corridors and cities while allowing governors or junior rulers to become autonomous. **Qualification:** a shared title does not prove identical powers everywhere.

Claim: Maues anchors an early north-western phase. **Evidence:** Taxila-region inscriptions and coins place Moga/Maues within inherited Indo-Greek monetary languages. **Analysis:** newcomers adapted existing institutions. **Qualification:** his exact date, capital and conquests remain debated.

Claim: Nahapana's Kshaharata network connected western routes, donations and Deccan rivalry. **Evidence:** Ushavadata's Nashik-Karle records and Gautamiputra Satakarni's overstrikes. **Analysis:** inscription and coin converge on patronage and political displacement. **Qualification:** neither source maps every campaign.

Claim: Rudradaman's Kardamaka power joined sovereignty, public works and Sanskrit praise. **Evidence:** the Shaka-year-72 Junagadh inscription records Sudarshana-lake repair and conflict with a Satakarni. **Analysis:** it demonstrates regional state capacity and courtly legitimation. **Qualification:** it is a prashasti, not neutral reportage.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive, uses named evidence analytically and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Underline each causal verb and source-status qualifier; never add an unverified date, quotation or official key.

ORIGINAL MAINS 15-MARKER 2 - Kushana formation and imperial geography

Question: Explain the formation and political geography of the Kushana Empire from Kujula Kadphises to Vasudeva. (15 marks; maximum 250 words)

Demand decoding: Explain requires a chronological mechanism joined to centres, titles and evidence limits.

Model answer (175 words):

Kushana power grew through staged migration and consolidation. **Claim:** the Great Yuezhi moved west and occupied Bactria. **Evidence:** Chinese histories, correlated with Central Asian archaeology, describe five principalities and the rise of Guishuang. **Analysis:** Kushana formation was a political regrouping, not a single raid. **Qualification:** translated ethnonyms and dates require correlation.

Claim: Kujula Kadphises consolidated the dynasty south of the Hindu Kush. **Evidence:** his coins adapt earlier Hermaeus types and royal titles. **Analysis:** numismatic continuity helped legitimise new authority. **Qualification:** precise territorial stages remain uncertain. Vima Kadphises' gold/copper issues display greater fiscal and ideological capacity; Kanishka's Rabatak inscription then supplies genealogy, Bactrian-in-Greek-script titulature and eastern city claims. **Qualification:** the older 78 CE accession thesis is disputed; a major modern chronology places Kanishka around 127 CE.

Under Kanishka, Huvishka and Vasudeva, Bactria, Kapisa/Begram, Purushapura, Taxila and Mathura acted as major centres. *Shaonano shao* and *devaputra* exalted kingship, while satraps and local institutions mediated rule.

Conclusion: the empire was transregional and multi-centred, but coin circulation and rhetorical city lists cannot be converted into uniform borders.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive, uses named evidence analytically and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Underline each causal verb and source-status qualifier; never add an unverified date, quotation or official key.

ORIGINAL MAINS 20-MARKER 1 - Mutual impact

Question: 'Central Asian contacts transformed post-Mauryan India through interaction rather than invasion alone.' Discuss. (20 marks; maximum 250 words)

Demand decoding: Discuss requires political, economic, social and cultural mechanisms, followed by a graded qualification.

Model answer (182 words):

Central Asian entry involved conflict, but its durable history arose from settlement, routes and institutional adaptation.

Claim: frontier polities altered kingship. **Evidence:** Indo-Greek portrait coins, Shaka *kshatrapa/mahakshatrapa* titles and Kushana *shaonano shao/devaputra*. **Analysis:** rulers translated authority across Iranian, Hellenistic and Indic idioms. **Qualification:** actual administration varied regionally.

Claim: exchange networks expanded. **Evidence:** Bactria-Gandhara-Mathura corridors, western ports, Kushana gold/copper and Kshatrapa silver. **Analysis:** customs, caravan cities, guilds and monasteries connected Central Asian, Chinese, Roman and Indian Ocean circuits. **Qualification:** coins show selective monetisation, not universal prosperity or route monopoly.

Claim: cultural production became cosmopolitan. **Evidence:** Greek-Kharoshthi bilingual issues, Bactrian in Greek script, Rudradaman's Sanskrit, plural Kushana deities, and Gandhara-Mathura workshops. **Analysis:** patrons and artisans created new regional forms. **Qualification:** style is not ethnicity and royal imagery is not a belief census.

Claim: social and military practices changed. **Evidence:** mobile elites, donations, tunics, trousers and cavalry imagery. **Analysis:** integration involved service, marriage, craft and cult. **Qualification:** true-stirrup diffusion and one-way invention claims remain unsafe. Thus the age produced negotiated, unequal synthesis-not passive Indianisation or invasion-only change.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive, uses named evidence analytically and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Underline each causal verb and source-status qualifier; never add an unverified date, quotation or official key.

ORIGINAL MAINS 20-MARKER 2 - Sources, chronology and limits

Question: Why are the chronology and political geography of the Indo-Greeks, Shakas and Kushanas difficult to reconstruct? Evaluate the available sources. (20 marks; maximum 250 words)

Demand decoding: Evaluate requires a hierarchy of sources, examples of conflict and a method for bounded conclusions.

Model answer (177 words):

The archive is rich but discontinuous. **Claim:** coins provide the densest ruler evidence. **Evidence:** Indo-Greek portraits and monograms, Nahapana overstrikes, and Kushana legends identify rulers, metals and circulation.

Analysis: die links and overstrikes build relative sequences. **Qualification:** mobile coins do not fix exact borders or personal belief.

Claim: inscriptions create dated anchors. **Evidence:** Heliodorus records diplomacy, Junagadh combines Shaka year 72 with Rudradaman's prashasti, Takht-i-Bahi anchors Gondophares, and Rabatak gives Kushana genealogy and claims. **Analysis:** epigraphy locates titles, donors and political language. **Qualification:** damage, rhetoric, era conversion and selective survival limit precision.

Claim: texts broaden geography and memory. **Evidence:** Chinese histories trace Yuezhi movement; classical writers discuss Bactria and trade; the *Milindapanha* remembers Menander; Buddhist traditions associate Kanishka with a council. **Analysis:** they preserve evidence absent from material records. **Qualification:** translation, genre and temporal distance forbid literal reading.

Archaeology and art history add centres, workshops and routes, but material style cannot identify ethnicity. Therefore chronology must use ranges and regional overlap; political maps must distinguish direct rule, influence and circulation. Triangulation yields defensible probabilities, not false certainty.

Executable answer spine: thesis -> claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification -> graded verdict.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive, uses named evidence analytically and remains within the stated ceiling.

Answer-specific improvement: Underline each causal verb and source-status qualifier; never add an unverified date, quotation or official key.